

Wayne Madsen



Italy's remarkable run to its debut appearance at the T20 World Cup was led by former Australia opener Joe Burns. However, with Burns missing from the squad for the tournament, the captaincy has passed to a figure who is no stranger to elite international sport.

Madsen initially represented South Africa in hockey, featuring at the 2006 Commonwealth Games and the World Cup, before switching codes to cricket. After a brief spell in South Africa's First-Class system, he moved to England, where he developed into a consistent County Championship performer.

An England call-up never materialised, but Madsen's formidable First-Class record for Derbyshire underlines his credentials, with over 20,000 runs amassed across formats. He is also well-versed in franchise cricket, having featured in the T20 Blast, The Hundred (London Spirit and Manchester Originals), the SA20 (Joburg Super Kings) and the PSL (Peshawar Zalmi).

Madsen's Italy bow came in 2023, when he made himself available for the country's push to qualify for the 2024 T20 World Cup, announcing his arrival with 52 on debut against Jersey. While his international record remains modest (166 runs from six matches), he will lean heavily on his vast domestic experience when leading Italy at its first World Cup.



Muhammad Waseem



The UAE returns to the T20 World Cup after missing the 2024 edition, with its campaign set to be fronted by captain, leading run-scorer and talisman Muhammad Waseem at the top of the order.

An aggressive wicketkeeper-batter, Waseem's journey with UAE cricket began in the club circuit. His international debut came in 2021 against Namibia, and just four games into his career, he announced himself with a blistering 107 not out from 62 balls against Ireland.

He has since carved out a prolific opening career for the UAE, scoring 3,184 runs from 91 matches at an average of 37.02 and a strike rate of 151.76. Waseem has also led the side at multiple international tournaments, including the Asia Cup 2025, which was hosted in the UAE.

He arrives at the World Cup in red-hot form, having finished as the ILT20 2025-26's second-highest run-getter with 370 runs at an average of 30.83 and a strike rate of 131.67 as MI Emirates reached the final. He also claimed the Blue Belt — awarded to the tournament's best UAE player — for a fourth consecutive season.

